



BUILD GUIDE

THE 400 SQUARE FOOT GARAGE GYM

Three build levels, a floor plan, and the honest cost of each — for a home gym that trains every pattern a strong body needs, in the space you already have.

FOOTPRINT

400 sq ft

LEVEL 1

from \$3,086

LEVEL 2

from \$3,635

LEVEL 3

from \$4,660

MIN CEILING

8 ft

HOW THIS BUILD THINKS

Most home gyms get built as a pile of purchases. Somebody buys a rack, then a bench, then whatever showed up in an ad, and two years later there's \$8,000 of steel in a garage that still can't train a hamstring.

This build starts from the other end. Decide what has to be trainable, then buy the smallest number of pieces that cover it. It's built in three levels, and **every level is a complete gym on its own** — not a partial one waiting on the next purchase.

The equipment isn't the system. The equipment is what makes the system possible on the days you don't feel like driving anywhere.

THE SIX PATTERNS

A complete strength setup has to load all six. If a pattern has no tool, it doesn't get trained.

PATTERN	COVERED AT LEVEL 1	IMPROVED LATER
Squat	Barbell front & back squat, dumbbell split squats	Rack safeties (L2), belt squat (L3)
Hinge	Barbell deadlift & RDL, Hyper Pro back extension and reverse hyper	Rack pulls (L2)
Push	Bench press, overhead press, dumbbell pressing	Cable crossover (L2), stryker pad (L3)
Pull	Barbell & dumbbell rows	Pull-ups, lat pulldown (L2)
Single leg & knee	Leg Developer extensions and curls, split squats	Matrix & hybrid board (L3)
Carry & conditioning	Dumbbell carries, open floor	Kettlebell (optional add)

WHY THE BARBELL IS IN THE BASE

The bench and the Leg Developer are both **plate-loaded**. Without a barbell and a plate set, the bench has nothing to press and the Leg Developer has nothing to lift. They are not an upgrade — they're what makes Level 1 function at all.

THE ONE DEPENDENCY TO UNDERSTAND

The Leg Developer's **optional \$49 cable attachment** only does something if you own a functional trainer with cables. That's the rig at Level 2. Buying the cable attachment before you own the rig buys you a bracket that connects to nothing — which is why it sits at Level 3, not Level 1.

THE THREE LEVELS

Each level contains everything in the level before it. Flooring is priced separately on page 7 because it applies to all three.

LEVEL ONE

\$3,086–\$3,286

THE BASE

APEX Adjustable Bench · APEX Leg Developer · FreakAthlete Hyper Pro · NÜOBELL adjustable dumbbells · barbell and 335 lb plate set.

Presses, squats, deadlifts, rows, leg extensions and curls, nordic curls, back extensions, reverse hypers, and every dumbbell movement from 5 to 100 lb per hand. A complete gym with no rack in the room.

LEVEL TWO

\$3,635–\$3,835

ADD THE RIG

Everything above, plus the EonfitOmni E2 2.0 Power Rack.

Adds safeties for squatting and pressing alone, a pull-up bar, dip station, landmine, and a full cable stack with lat pulldown and crossover. This is the level that makes training heavy by yourself safe.

LEVEL THREE

\$4,660–\$4,860

ADD THE ATTACHMENTS

Everything above, plus the five APEX bench attachments: Barrett Belt Squat, Matrix Machine, Hybrid Board, Stryker Pad, and the Leg Developer cable system.

Specialty work — spine-free squat volume, sissy squats and hip thrusts, tibialis and calf training, chest-supported rows, and cable resistance. Refinement, not foundation.

WHAT EACH LEVEL COSTS

	LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2	LEVEL 3
Equipment	\$2,636	\$3,185	\$4,210
Barbell & 335 lb plates	\$450–\$650	\$450–\$650	\$450–\$650
Level total	\$3,086–\$3,286	\$3,635–\$3,835	\$4,660–\$4,860
+ Flooring (page 7)	\$510–\$1,600	\$510–\$1,600	\$510–\$1,600
+ Optional adds	\$494	\$494	\$534

Optional adds: NÜOBELL floor stand \$195, adjustable kettlebell \$299 (or \$548 for a matched pair — see page 8), squat belt \$40 (Level 3 only — the Barrett Belt Squat ships without one).

THE BASE — \$3,086 TO \$3,286

ITEM	WHAT IT BUYS YOU	PRICE	AVAILABILITY
APEX Adjustable Bench apexfitness.com/products/apex-adjustable-bench	FID bench for all pressing, plus the mounting chassis every APEX attachment bolts to. Stores vertically.	\$499	IN STOCK
APEX Leg Developer leg extension & curl apexfitness.com/products/apex-leg-trainer-cable-system	Seated leg extension and lying leg curl, plate-loaded . 27" × 20" × 30", 48 lb, 300 lb capacity. Bolts to the bench. Stores loaded.	\$439 was \$559	PRE-ORDER ships early Nov
FreakAthlete Hyper Pro freakathlete.co/products/hyper-pro	Nordic curls, back extensions, GHD sit-ups, glute-ham raises, reverse hyps, hip thrusts — 25+ movements. 500 lb rated, 108 lb. Stands 22" × 23" × 60" stored upright, on transport wheels. GHD attachment included.	\$699 was \$799	IN STOCK
NÜOBELL S 5100 (Forest) nuoathletics.com/products/nuobell-s-5100-forest	5–100 lb per hand in 5 lb increments, sold as a pair. Twist-handle selection. Replaces roughly 20 pairs of fixed dumbbells.	\$999	IN STOCK
Required — the bench and Leg Developer do not load without these			
Olympic barbell 7 ft, 20 kg	Every press, squat, deadlift and row at Level 1. A 1,000 lb-rated 28mm bar is plenty; you do not need a competition bar.	\$200–\$350	WIDELY AVAILABLE
Plate set — 335 lb	4×45, 2×35, 2×25, 2×10, 2×5, 2×2.5. Cast iron is the value pick. Cheapest route is a standard 300 lb set with bar plus one extra pair of 45s.	\$250–\$400	WIDELY AVAILABLE

Level 1 total

\$3,086–\$3,286

BUY THE BAR AND PLATES AS ONE COMBO SET

A 300 lb cast iron Olympic set with a 7 ft bar typically runs **\$300–\$500** and covers everything on the plate spec except one pair of 45s. Adding that pair separately (~\$90–\$140) lands you at the full 335 lb for less than buying plates individually. Go bumper plates instead only if you intend to deadlift heavy and drop the bar — expect to pay roughly double.

THE ONE ALTERNATIVE WORTH KNOWING ABOUT

FreakAthlete's [FA Adjustable Dumbbell](#) (\$1,299.99/pair, 10–120 lb) does the same job as the NÜOBELL. Take it *instead*, never as well — two sets is \$2,300 doing one job. It's worth the swap only if you need 120 lb per hand, plan to drop them, and can wait: it ships **end of 2026** against the NÜOBELL's today.

ADD THE RIG — \$3,635 TO \$3,835

ITEM	WHAT IT BUYS YOU	PRICE	AVAILABILITY
Everything in Level 1		\$3,086–\$3,286	
EonfitOmni E2 2.0 Power Rack eonfitfitness.com also on Amazon	1,500 lb capacity, 61"W × 62.5"L × 85"H, 220 lb. Ships with pull-up bar, dip bar, safety arms, landmine, j-hooks, plate storage pins, and a full pulley system with lat bar, straight bar and tricep rope.	\$549	IN STOCK
Level 2 total		\$3,635–\$3,835	

WHAT \$549 ACTUALLY CHANGES

Training alone gets safe

Adjustable safety arms mean you can fail a squat or a bench press with nobody home. Without them, every heavy set in the garage is capped by what you're willing to risk — which is usually well under what you could actually lift.

The cable stack

Lat pulldown, seated row, crossover, face pulls, triceps, and the resistance source the Leg Developer's cable attachment plugs into at Level 3.

Vertical pulling

The pull-up bar closes the only real gap in Level 1. Barbell and dumbbell rows train horizontal pulling well; nothing at Level 1 trains a vertical pull.

Plate storage

335 lb of iron has to live somewhere. The rack's storage pins get it off the floor and out of the walkway, which matters more in 400 sq ft than it sounds.

WHAT YOUR CEILING ALLOWS

This is the one item in the guide that cannot be worked around after delivery. For a tall lifter the pull-up bar gets the attention, but **cable travel** is what you feel every session — a high pulley on a short rack turns a lat pulldown into a half rep.

CONSTRAINT	8 FT CEILING (96")	10 FT CEILING (120")
Rack height	85" max. 11" of headroom.	Takes a 90–93" rack, 27" to spare.
Pull-ups	Bar ~83". A 6'2"+ lifter hangs knees well bent.	Bar at 90"+. Closer to a full dead hang.
Standing press	Marginal when tall. A 6'4" lockout is ~92".	Comfortable at any height.
Lat pulldown	Low pulley, short stroke. Tall lifters run out of cable.	High origin, long stroke. The reason to go tall.

Pages 6–7 pick the rig for each ceiling — including the taller options that use a 10 ft room.

If the ceiling won't take the rack, stay at Level 1 and put the \$549 toward flooring and a second kettlebell. Level 1 is a real gym.

CHOOSING THE RIG FOR YOUR CEILING

Measure floor to the *lowest* obstruction — garage door track, opener, joist — against the ceiling constraints on page 5.

CEILING	RIG	COST	WHY
8 ft one clear answer	EonfitOmni E2 2.0 eonfitfitness.com	\$549	85", everything integrated — crossover, lat pulldown, dip, landmine, pull-up bar. Nothing taller clears the ceiling, so there's no trade to weigh.
8 ft alternative	Mikolo K6-2.0 Ultra all-in-one trainer gym-mikolo.com · k6-2-0-ultra	\$799.99	86.5" — 1.5" taller than the Eonfit, so it does not solve a tall ceiling. Strong hardware: 1,500 lb j-hooks, 600 lb per cable side, 10+ attachments. Cable is plate-loaded 2:1; the selectorized stack is a separate upgrade — confirm it ships before counting on it.
10 ft recommended	REP Altitude Rack, 90" + Altitude Cable Attachment repfitness.com · altitude-power-rack repfitness.com · altitude-rack-cable-attachment	\$2,643 \$765 + \$1,878	Order the 90" uprights, not the 83" — REP states the 83" has shorter range of motion for lat pulldowns and trolley height. Dual selectorized stacks run independently, so full cable travel one arm or two.
10 ft value	Titan X-3, 91" + lat tower & low row titan.fitness · lat-tower-rack-attachment	~\$1,090 ~\$700 + ~\$390	1,650 lb capacity, bar ~8" higher than the Eonfit. The tower is plate-loaded , 300 lb cap — a pulldown and low row, not a dual-cable trainer.
Any ceiling cable alternative	Beyond Power VOLTRA I digital resistance beyond-power.com/products/voltra	\$2,199	Replaces the <i>cable attachment</i> , not the rack. 12.8 lb and shoebox-sized, it mounts anywhere on a rack or wall — so you set the pulley height instead of buying it. 5-200 lb of true resistance , more than the Altitude's 135 lb feel, plus eccentric overload, isokinetic and custom curves no stack can do. One cable, battery powered, currently sold out .

RIG NOTES & BUDGET IMPACT

HOW TO CHOOSE IN ONE PASS

IF THIS IS TRUE	BUY THIS
Ceiling is 8 ft	Eonfit E2 (\$549). Nothing taller fits. Spend the savings on flooring.
Ceiling is 8 ft and you want better hardware	Mikolo K6-2.0 (\$800). Same height class, heavier-duty cables and j-hooks.
Ceiling is 10 ft, budget is tight	Titan X-3 91" + lat tower (~\$1,090). Buys the height, not the cable stack.
Ceiling is 10 ft, lifter is tall, budget allows	REP Altitude 90" + cable, 270 lb stacks (\$3,093). The complete answer.
You want the most capability per dollar and can wait	Titan 91" + Voltra (\$2,899). More resistance than the Altitude, pulley height you choose.

THE ALTITUDE'S CABLE RUNS 2:1 — TAKE THE STACK UPGRADE

Dual 170 lb stacks run 2:1 — **170 lb feels like 85 lb**, light for a big lifter on lat pulldowns from day one. The upgrade to **270 lb stacks (135 lb feel)** is **+\$450**, and retrofitting later is not a cheap afternoon. Budget **\$3,093** for the rig done properly.

ORDERING GOTCHAS

RIG	CHECK BEFORE YOU PAY
Titan X-3	The <i>Flat Foot</i> version has no side or top holes and will not take the lat tower . Order the bolt-down or standard version. The tall-rack tower is the ~\$390 part, not the ~\$350 one.
REP Altitude	Order 90" uprights, not 83" — REP states the 83" has shorter range of motion for lat pulldowns and trolley height. The cable attachment is priced separately from the rack.
Mikolo K6-2.0	The cable is plate-loaded out of the box. The 160 lb selectorized stack is a separate upgrade — confirm it is actually shipping before you count on it.
Voltra I	Sold out at the manufacturer as of August 2026. It is one cable, not two, and it is battery powered — a charging habit, not a plug-in.
All of them	Measure floor to the lowest obstruction, not the highest point. Garage door tracks and openers are what actually bite.

WHAT THIS DOES TO THE BUDGET

Every level total in this guide is priced on the **\$549 Eonfit**. Against that: Mikolo **+\$251**, Titan **+\$541**, Titan + Voltra **+\$2,350**, Altitude with upgraded stacks **+\$2,544** — which takes Level 3 to roughly **\$7,200** before flooring. The rig is the piece you touch every session for the next decade, and the one thing here a tall lifter notices immediately. It is also the easiest place to overspend.

ADD THE ATTACHMENTS — \$4,660 TO \$4,860

ITEM	WHAT IT BUYS YOU	PRICE	AVAILABILITY
Everything in Level 2		\$3,635–\$3,835	
APEX Barrett Belt Squat apexfitness.com · apex-barrett-belt-squat-machine	Belt squats, standing calf raises, RDLs, shrugs. 66" lever arm, 450 lb capacity. Stores vertically at 12" × 19.5" × 31". Belt sold separately (~\$40).	\$299 was \$399	PRE-ORDER ships early Nov
APEX Matrix Machine apexfitness.com/products/apex-matrix-machine	Sissy squats, hip thrusts, split squats, preacher curls. 25" × 21.5" × 18", 35 lb. Loads with dumbbells, barbell, or the rig's cables.	\$299 was \$399	PRE-ORDER ships early Nov
APEX Hybrid Board apexfitness.com · apex-hybrid-board	Slant board, tib machine, calf block, and belt squat platform in one. 18" × 24" × 8", 1,000 lb capacity, 35 lb.	\$229 was \$299	IN STOCK
APEX Stryker Pad apexfitness.com · apex-stryker-pad	Shoulder press, chest-supported seal rows, single-arm preacher curls, seated rows. 13 lb, 500 lb capacity.	\$149 was \$199	PRE-ORDER ships end Sept
Leg Developer Cable System apexfitness.com · apex-leg-extension-cable-system	Bolt-on that links the Leg Developer to the rig's cable stack for constant-tension, plate-free resistance. 350 lb rated. Requires the Level 2 rack.	\$49 was \$59	IN STOCK
Level 3 total		\$4,660–\$4,860	

APEX NAMES TWO OF THESE ALMOST IDENTICALLY

The **\$439 Leg Developer machine** (Level 1) and the **\$49 cable add-on** above have nearly identical names and near-swapped URLs on the APEX site. Every link here points to the page that sells that row's item — but confirm the on-screen price matches the table before you pay.

OPTIONAL ADDS, ANY LEVEL

NÜOBELL Floor Stand nuoathletics.com/products/nuobell-floor-stand	Cradles the dumbbells at lifting height. 29" × 22" × 24". Keeps 200 lb off the floor.	\$195	IN STOCK
Adjustable Kettlebell — single freakathlete.co/products/kettlebell	12–32 kg (26–70 lb) in 2 kg steps. Cast iron, magnetized locking pin. Replaces a rack of ten.	\$299 was \$349	PRE-ORDER ships by Sept 30
Adjustable Kettlebell — matched pair freakathlete.co/products/kettlebell	Two bells together. Unlocks double-bell work — front squats, cleans, presses, carries — which one bell can't train. \$50 cheaper than two singles.	\$548 vs \$598	PRE-ORDER ships by Sept 30

FLOORING

Priced separately because it applies to all three levels — and because it's the one line item people skip, then regret. Bare concrete cracks plates, wrecks joints, and turns every dropped dumbbell into a repair bill.

THE TWO OPTIONS

	HORSE STALL MATS	PURPOSE-MADE GYM FLOORING
Cost, 400 sq ft	\$510–\$780 ~17 mats at \$30–\$46 each	\$800–\$1,600 \$2–\$4 per sq ft
Size & thickness	4 ft × 6 ft × 3/4", 24 sq ft per mat	Rolls or tiles, 3/8" to 3/4"
Weight	~100 lb per mat — a two-person job, and they don't fit in a sedan	Rolls are heavy; tiles are one-person friendly
Material	100% recycled vulcanized rubber, made for barns	Recycled rubber manufactured to indoor emission standards
Smell	Strong. See below.	Mild, typically clears in days to a couple of weeks
Where	Tractor Supply, Rural King, farm supply stores	Specialty flooring and fitness retailers

THE STALL MAT TRADE-OFF — READ BEFORE YOU SAVE THE \$400

Horse stall mats are the cheapest good floor in home gyms, and they're genuinely durable. But they are manufactured for **barns and stables**, not sealed rooms. They're made to a durability and cost spec, not an indoor emissions spec, and they off-gas volatile organic compounds far more aggressively than fitness-grade rubber.

Expect a strong rubber smell for **weeks at minimum**. Stall mats commonly take two to three weeks longer to off-gas than dedicated gym flooring, and owners regularly report a lingering smell past a year in poorly ventilated spaces. In an attached garage that shares air with the house, that smell will find the house.

IF YOU GO WITH STALL MATS

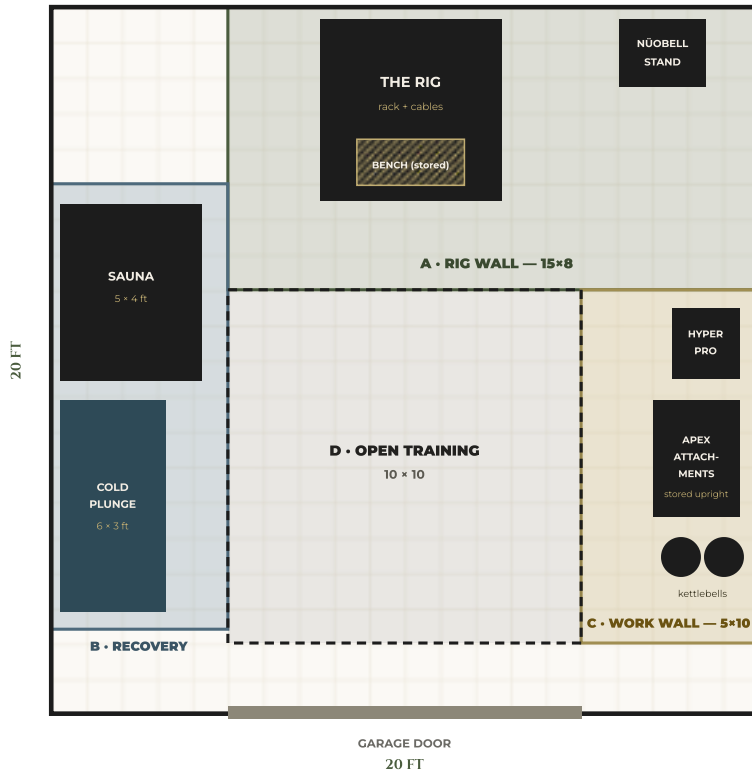
This protocol is the difference between a floor you tolerate and one you resent:

- **Air them outdoors for two full weeks before installing.** Stand them up, separated, under cover but in open air. This is the single highest-leverage step, and it's free.
- **Scrub both sides before they go down** — a degreaser or a simple vinegar-and-water wash pulls off surface residue that carries much of the odor.
- **Ventilate hard for another week after installing.** Garage door open, fan running.
- **Don't do this in a finished basement or a room that shares HVAC with bedrooms.** Buy the fitness-grade flooring instead. The \$400 you save isn't worth it.

Floor it before you load it. Retrofitting rubber under 220 lb of assembled rack and 335 lb of plates is a job nobody does twice.

THE FLOOR PLAN

Two working walls, one open middle. The rig wall carries barbell and cable work; the adjacent wall carries posterior chain, attachments and kettlebells. Garage door on the near wall.



A • Rig Wall — 120 sq ft

The rig against the 20 ft wall with the dumbbell stand beside it. **The bench stores vertically at the rig** and rolls out into the uprights for pressing — it doesn't need a footprint of its own. Leave 3 ft each side for plate loading and cable swing.

C • Work Wall — 50 sq ft

Adjacent wall: Hyper Pro, the APEX attachments stored upright, and kettlebells. All of it stores flat to the wall and pulls into the open floor to use.

D • Open Training — 100 sq ft

The center stays clear. This is where the Hyper Pro, belt squat and Matrix actually get used, plus carries, conditioning and stretching.

B • Recovery — 63 sq ft

Sauna and plunge together on the far wall, away from the garage door and off the lifting floor. Requirements below.

333 sq ft assigned, ~67 sq ft walkway.

Everything heavy lives against a wall and moves to the middle to be used. That's what makes 400 sq ft feel bigger than it is.

WHAT THE RECOVERY CORNER ACTUALLY NEEDS

Sauna — plan 5 ft × 4 ft

A 1–2 person cabin runs roughly 4×4 to 5×6. Add clearance for the door swing. Most plug-in infrared units want a **dedicated 20A circuit**; traditional and larger units often need 240V. Confirm the model's spec before you frame anything.

Cold plunge — plan 6 ft × 3 ft

Plus room to climb in. The chiller needs **airflow and its own GFCI outlet**, and you need a **drain plan** — floor drain, pump, or a hose run to the driveway. Keep the plunge off the lifting floor and seal the slab.

WHY THIS STILL WORKS IN A SMALLER ROOM

Every piece here was chosen to **store small and work big**. The bench stores vertically at the rig; the Hyper Pro folds to 22" × 23" on wheels; the belt squat, Matrix, hybrid board and stryker pad store upright against one wall. One NÜOBELL pair replaces about **20 pairs of fixed dumbbells** — a conventional 5–100 lb rack eats ~10 ft of wall, the stand takes 2.4 ft. Nothing holds floor space it isn't using: the equipment lives on the walls and comes out to meet you. **Take 100 sq ft off this plan and you lose a zone, not a capability.**

IF YOUR SPACE IS 15 × 20 INSTEAD OF 20 × 20

A standard two-car bay is often **300 sq ft, not 400**. At 15×20 both working walls still fit; the open middle shrinks to roughly 10×5 — enough for the Hyper Pro and belt squat, tight for carries. Cut the open floor last and the walkway never.



BEFORE YOU ORDER

SIX THINGS THAT SINK A GARAGE GYM BUILD

Measure the ceiling first. Under 8 ft and the rack's pull-up bar doesn't fit. Not fixable after delivery.

Buy the bar and plates with Level 1, not later. The bench and the Leg Developer are plate-loaded. Without them, Level 1 doesn't work.

Don't buy the cable attachment before the rig. It connects to a cable stack you won't own until Level 2.

Buy the bench before its attachments. Four items bolt to it and do nothing without it.

Pick one set of adjustable dumbbells. The NÜOBELL and the FA do the same job. Two sets is \$2,300 doing one.

Air out stall mats for two weeks outdoors. Or pay the extra \$400 for fitness-grade rubber and skip the smell entirely.

Build the room so the hard days are easy to start. That's the whole point of putting it thirty feet from your kitchen.